

Modals - Can and could

Use of can

Can is used to show **ability**, **permission**, and **possibility** in the **present**.

Structures: subject + can + base verb

Examples: She can swim. (ability)

Can I use your pen? (permission)

It can be dangerous. (possibility)

Use of could

Could is used to show **past ability**, **polite permission**, and **weak possibility**.

Structures: subject + could + base verb

Examples: She could swim when she was young. (past ability)

Could I come in, please? (polite permission)

It could rain today. (weak possibility)

Difference between can and could

Can → present ability or direct permission

Could → past ability or polite request

Negative forms

can not / cannot → cannot

could not → couldn't

Examples: She cannot drive.

He couldn't understand the question.

Interrogative forms

Can + subject + base verb?

Could + subject + base verb?

Examples: Can you help me?

Could you explain this?

Can and could are always followed by the base form of the verb.

present

past

Modals – May and might

Use of may

May is used to show **permission**, **possibility**, and **formal** requests.

Structures: subject + may + base verb

Examples: May I come in? (permission)

She may join us later. (possibility)

Use of might

Might is used to show **weak possibility** or **uncertainty**, usually less sure than may.

Structures: subject + might + base verb

Examples: It might rain today. (weak possibility)

She might be late. (uncertainty)

Difference between may and might

May → stronger possibility, more formal

Might → weaker possibility, more uncertain

Negative forms: may not might not

Examples: He may not agree.

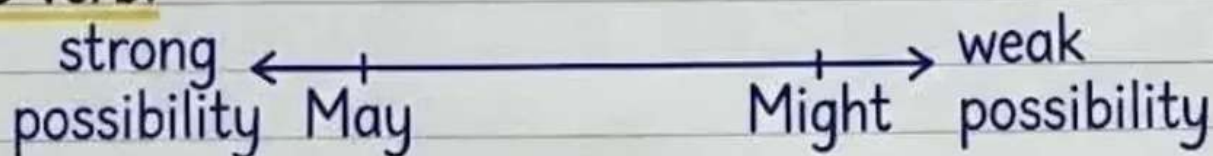
She might not come today.

Interrogative forms: May + subject + base verb?

Might + subject + base verb? (rare)

Example: May I leave early?

May and might are always followed by the base form of the verb.



Modals – Basic concept

What are modals?

Modals are **helping verbs** that express ability, permission, possibility, advice, obligation, or request.

Position of modals in a sentence

Modals are placed before the main verb.

Structure: subject + modal + **base form of verb**

She can swim.

He must study.

Important feature of modals

- Modals do not change according to subject
- Modals are **always followed by base form of verb**
- Modals **do not take "s", "es", "ing", or "ed"**

Common modal verbs

can, could, may, might, must, shall, should, will, would, ought to

Simple comparison

She plays. ✗

She can play. ✓

A modal is always followed by the base form of the verb.

subject → modal → base verb

Modals – Common errors and exam traps

Error 1: Using s or es with modals

Modals never take s or es, even with third person singular.

Wrong: He can plays cricket. ✗ ⚠

Correct: He can play cricket. ✓

Error 2: Using to after modals

Modals are followed by the base form of the verb without to.

Wrong: She must to go home. ✗ ⚠

Correct: She must go home. ✓

Error 3: Using do, does, or did with modals

Do, does, and did are not used with modal verbs.

Wrong: Do you can solve this? ✗ ⚠

Correct: Can you solve this? ✓

Error 4: Confusing must and have to

Must shows speaker's authority, while have to shows external rule or compulsion.

Error 5: Wrong use of modals with past reference

Past reference modals must use have + v³.

Wrong: He should went earlier. ✗ ⚠

Correct: He should have gone earlier. ✓

Quick exam tips

- Check the verb form after the modal
- Never add s, es, or to after modals
- Identify whether the meaning is present, future, or past
- Read the sentence meaning carefully before choosing the modal

If a modal is used, the main verb must be in base form.

Modals – Negative and interrogative forms

Negative form of modals

Negative sentences with modals are formed by adding **not** after the **modal verb**.

Structure: subject + modal + **not** + base verb

Example: She cannot swim.

He should not waste time.

They might not come today.

Common contracted forms

cannot → can't

should not → shouldn't

will not → won't

could not → couldn't

would not → wouldn't

might not → mightn't (rare)

Interrogative form of modals

Interrogative sentences with modals are formed by placing the **modal** before the **subject**.

Structure: modal + subject + base verb?

Can you help me?

Should we start now?

Would you like some tea?

Negative interrogative form

modal + subject + not + base verb?

Can you not hear me? Shouldn't we inform the teacher?

Important points

- No helping verb is used with modals
- **Main verb always stays in base form**
- **Do, does, and did are not used with modals**

With modals, **never use do, does, or did.**

Modals – Past reference (must have, could have, should have)

What are past reference modals?

Past reference modals are used to talk about past actions, guesses, regrets, or conclusions.

Basic structure

subject + modal + have + v³

Must have

Used to show strong certainty or logical conclusion about the past.

She must have missed the bus.

He must have worked very hard.

Could have

Used to show possibility in the past or unrealized chance.

She could have won the race.

We could have reached earlier.

Should have / ought to have

Used to show regret, criticism, or expectation not fulfilled.

You should have informed me earlier.

He ought to have helped his friend.

Negative forms must not have could not have should not have

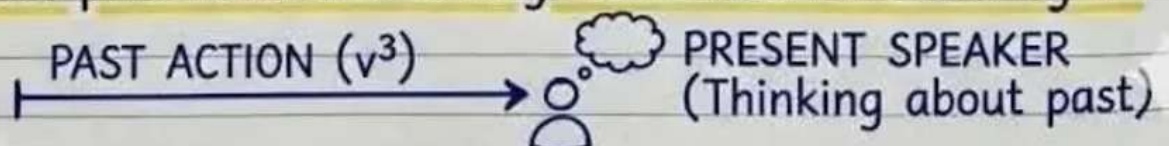
She must not have seen the notice.

He should not have shouted.

Important points

- Always use have + v³ after the modal
- These forms refer only to the past
- They are very common in exams and spoken English

Modals with past reference always use have followed by v³.



Modals - Types and general meanings

Classification of modals

Modals can be grouped based on the idea or meaning they express.

Modals of ability

These modals show power, skill, or capacity.

can, could - She can speak English.

Modals of permission

These modals are used to give or ask permission.

can, may, could - May I come in?

Modals of possibility

These modals show chance or likelihood.

may, might, could - It may rain today.

Modals of obligation and necessity

These modals show duty, rule, or strong need.

must, have to, ought to - You must follow the rules.

Modals of advice and suggestion

These modals are used to give advice or suggestion.

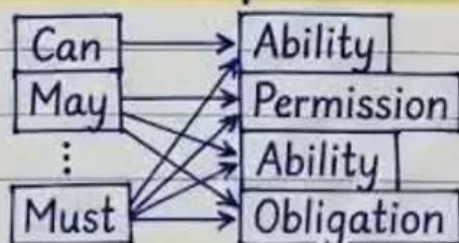
should, ought to - You should study regularly.

Modals of request and offer

These modals are used to make polite requests or offers.

can, could, would, shall - Could you help me?

The meaning of a modal depends on the situation in which it is used.



Modals – Uses, Meanings & Formulas

Modal Verb	Formula	Example	Usage / Meaning
1. Can	Sub + can + V' + Obj	I can swim.	ability / permission / possibility
2. Could	Sub + could + V' + Obj	He could run fast when he was young.	<u>past ability</u> / polite request / possibility
3. May	Sub + may + V' + Obj	You may go now.	<u>permission</u> / possibility / wish
4. Might	Sub + might + V' + Obj	It might rain today.	weak possibility / uncertainty
5. Must	Sub + must + V' + Obj	You must obey your parents.	<u>necessity</u> / duty / certainty
6. Shall	Sub + shall + V' + Obj	We shall meet tomorrow.	future intention / suggestion
7. Should	Sub + should + V' + Obj	You should study daily.	advice / moral duty
8. Will	Sub + will + V' + Obj	She will come soon.	future / willingness
9. Would	Sub + would + V' + Obj	I would help you if I could.	polite offer / imagination
10. Ought to	Sub + ought to + V' + Obj	You ought to respect elders.	<u>moral duty</u> / strong advice
11. Need to	Sub + need to + V' + Obj	You need to practice more.	necessity
12. Dare	Sub + dare not + V'	He dare not speak to the teacher.	courage (formal)
13. Used to	Sub + used to + V' + Obj	He used to play cricket.	past habit
14. Have to / Has to	Sub + have/has to + V' + Obj	I have to go now.	obligation
15. Had better	Sub + had better + V'	You had better leave now.	<u>strong advice</u> / warning

Modals – Must and have to

Use of must

Must is used to show strong obligation, duty, or necessity felt by the speaker.

Structure: subject + must + base verb

Example: You must follow the rules. (obligation)

She must study hard. (necessity)

Use of have to

Have to is used to show external obligation or compulsion due to rules or situations.

Structure: subject + have to / has to + base verb

Example: I have to wake up early. (external rule)

He has to wear a uniform. (rule)

Difference between must and have to

Must → speaker's personal feeling or authority

Have to → rule, law, or situation

Negative forms

must not → prohibition

do not have to → no necessity

Example: You must not smoke here.

You do not have to come tomorrow.

Interrogative forms

Must + subject + base verb?

Do / does + subject + have to + base verb?

Example: Must I attend the meeting?

Do you have to wear a uniform?

Must shows strong obligation, have to shows compulsion due to rules.

Speaker Control	Rule Control
(Must)	(Have to)

Modals – Probability and certainty

What is probability and certainty?

Probability shows how likely something is to happen, while **certainty** shows complete confidence.

Modals showing weak probability

These modals show low chance or uncertainty.

may, might, could – It may rain today.

She might be at home.

He could be late.

Modals showing strong probability

These modals show a high chance.

should, ought to – The train should arrive on time.

He ought to reach by evening.

Modals showing certainty

These modals show complete **certainty** or **logical conclusion**.

must – She must be tired after the journey.

This must be the right answer.

Comparison scale

might → may → could → should → must
(from weak probability to strong certainty)

Important note

Here, must does not show obligation, it shows **logical certainty**.

The stronger the belief, the stronger the modal used.

weak probability ← might may could should must → strong certainty

Modals – Requests, offers, and invitations

Modals used for requests

Requests are polite ways of asking someone to do something.

Common modals used: can, could, may, would

Examples: Can you help me?

Could you open the window, please?

May I use your phone?

Would you explain this again?

Modals used for offers

Offers are made to show willingness to help or give something.

Common modals used: shall, will, can

Examples: Shall I carry your bag?

I will help you with your homework.

Can I get you some water?

Modals used for invitations

Invitations are used to invite someone politely.

Common modals used: would, will, can

Examples: Would you like to join us for dinner?

Will you come to my birthday party?

Can you come to my house tomorrow?

Level of politeness

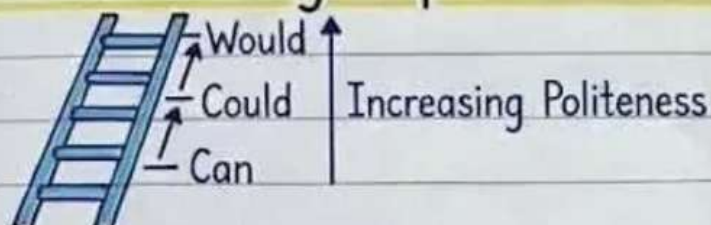
Can → informal

Would → very polite

Could → more polite

May → formal

Choose the modal according to politeness and situation.



Modals - Should and ought to

Use of should

Should is used to give advice, suggestion, opinion, or mild obligation.

Structure: subject + should + base verb

Examples: You should study regularly. (advice)

She should see a doctor. (suggestion)

Use of ought to

Ought to is used to show moral duty, strong advice, or responsibility.

Structure: subject + ought to + base verb

Examples: You ought to respect your elders. (moral duty)

We ought to help the poor. (responsibility)

Difference between should and ought to

Should → common advice or suggestion

Ought to → moral or strong duty

Negative forms: should not / shouldn't
ought not to

Examples: You should not waste time.

He ought not to lie.

Interrogative forms

Should + subject + base verb?

Ought + subject + to + base verb?

Examples: Should I call him now?

Ought we to inform the teacher?

Should and ought to are used to give advice or show duty.

Common Advice (Should)	Moral Duty (Ought to)
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